

A Case for Language Acquisition

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Introduction: In this paper, we propose a conceptual framework that we believe creates points of interface between research in language acquisition and that in early childhood education (ECE) in preschools and schools. While generative theories of language acquisition have viewed the development of language in children as an interplay of nature and nurture, the latter's significance has been more popular in the form of a triggering mechanism for the former to manifest.

Generativists' theoretical conception about the process of language acquisition holds it to be shaped by (a) Universal Grammar (UG), (b) experience, i.e., the language-particular input from the environment, and (c) 'third factors' which include principles that are not specific to the language faculty (Chomsky, 2005), such as "... principles of hypothesis formation and data analysis, which are used both in language acquisition and in the acquisition of knowledge in other cognitive domains" (Yang et al., 2017, p. 2). Experience, we believe, must be interpreted in two senses to capture the fullness of what acquiring a language entails. In the strictly linguistic sense, it is experience of the primary linguistic data (PLD) that enables the child to set the parameters of UG relevant to her language, e.g., to determine whether the language is SVO or SOV. In addition, a second sense of experience has also been flagged out as relevant, which involves the learning of those aspects of language that do not fall out from the principles and parameters of UG. In this is included the learning of phonological, lexical, and other regularities of grammar that do not fall out from UG principles. As Yang (2004, p. 451) puts it: "...it is a truism that both endowment and learning contribute to language acquisition, the result of which is an extremely sophisticated body of linguistic knowledge. Consequently, both must be considered, explicitly, in a theory of language acquisition."

Here, we present primary data from Hindi child language in the domain of oblique morphology, and *-ko* and *-se* case marked objects, as well as Bangla child language for the use of formal marking on 3rd person pronouns, to illustrate the role of experiential input in complementing the innate grammatical capacity on the path to linguistic fluency.

The use of oblique morphology in Hindi child language data: Oblique forms of nouns in Hindi contrast with direct forms. The former appears in the form of a suffix or morphological suppletion on a declension class of nouns in the presence of a postposition (Butt & King, 2004, among others). The noun *baccaa* 'male child' and *haath* 'hand/hands' appear in oblique form in (6). The demonstrative pronoun *ye* 'this' and the adjective *achaa* 'good' undergo oblique concord with the noun as part of the noun phrase, since the subject and the object arguments are followed by ergative (*-ne*) and accusative (*-ko*) marking postpositions respectively.¹

- (1) *is* *ache* *bacce-ne* *haathoN-ko* *dhoyaa*
this.OBL.SG good.OBL.M.SG child.OBL.M.SG-ERG hands.OBL-ACC WASH.PERF
'this good child washed (his) hands.'

In a Hindi child language corpus (46 children; age range - 23 to 71 months) of 13,804 utterances (Pareek, 2017), consisting of 14,637 overt nouns/noun phrases, a very high rate of accuracy (97%) was seen in the 2,521 obligatory contexts for oblique morphology. Oblique omissions

¹ Glossing conventions: 1P – first person, 2P – second person, 3P – third person, ACC – accusative, AUX – auxiliary, CLF – classifier, DAT – dative, ERG – ergative, F – feminine, FUT – future, GEN – genitive, L1 – level 1, L2 – level 2, L3 – level 3, M – masculine, NF – nonfinite, NOM – nominative, OBL – oblique, PERF – perfect, PFV – perfective, PL – plural, PRS – present, PST – past, SG – singular

on noun phrases consisting of only a noun (no modifier), comprised 15.09% of the errors. Oblique omissions on demonstratives/modifiers of noun phrases where the noun is of a non-inflecting class were the next highest (13.53%). A very small number of omissions were seen on both modifier/s and modified noun in a complex noun phrase (6.98%), and only on the noun with grammatical oblique on the modifier (5.81%). There are no instances of errors where the omission is on the modifier with a grammatical oblique on the modified noun. In other words, if the modified noun is of an inflecting class and has been grammatically inflected for oblique, children are likely to apply oblique concord on the modifier.

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|-----|---|---------------|------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|------------|
| (2) | <i>jaadugar</i> | <i>parii</i> | <i>-ko</i> | <i>gale</i> | <i>lagaa</i> | <i>rahaa</i> | <i>hE</i> |
| | magician | fairy | -ACC | neck | put | PROG.F.SG | AUX.PRS.3P |
| | ‘The magician is hugging the fairy’ | | | | | | |
| | | | | | | | |
| (3) | <i>raajaa</i> | <i>laRkii</i> | <i>-se</i> | <i>haath</i> | <i>milaa</i> | <i>rahaa</i> | <i>hE</i> |
| | king | girl | -COMM | hand.M | meet.PERF | PROG.M.SG | AUX.PRS.3P |
| | ‘The king is shaking hands with the girl’ | | | | | | |

The use of formal pronouns in Bangla child language data: Polite pronouns in Bangla, which are a set distinct from plural pronouns, are found to be extremely sparse in Bangla-speaking children’s repertoire of the language, appearing only around age six.

- (4) *o* ... *onar-i* (bch09:5;9)
 o ... 3P.SG.L3.GEN-i
 ‘his (formal)’

three children, all nearly six years of age or older were the only ones whose pronoun repertoire showed the use of formal pronouns. The most prevalent error type in children's formal pronoun production was replacing the non-formal with the formal. There were 102 instances of these, such as (6) below, across the three tasks.

- (5) *eTa onar bag Tebil-e rakh(a)* (bch19:6;10)
 this 3P.SG.L3.GEN bag table-LOC kept
 'this is her bag kept on the table.'
- (6) *#dida_i-r bæg-e or_i* (bch22:4;0)
 dida-GEN bag-LOC 3P.SG.L2.GEN
fon khūjchhe
 phone searching.3P
 '(Grandma) is searching for her_i phone in Grandma_i's bag'

These results are consistent with what is known in the literature about the acquisition timeline of politeness (Nakamura, 2001). Further, Bangla speaking adults too in anecdotes recount how their formal pronoun usage was explicitly corrected in the home and at school. The Bangla child data demonstrates that there are language-specific rules that may not follow from the innate linguistic capacity but follow a course of grammatical errors till a relatively older age, which get corrected with increased exposure to socio-cultural contexts that demand the rule.

Discussion: The acquisition of language is an "acquisition + learning" process. Some features, like case marking, are acquired. The grammatical "errors" in the Hindi acquisition data reveals instances of rules that children appear to master with high accuracy despite an impoverished input provided by limited experience at an incredibly early age. Others, like politeness, are almost 'learnt', being dependent on the frequency of use in a child's environment, which may further depend upon several factors such as unambiguous communicative needs and socio-cultural norms of expression. Most of these needs arise when the child exits the world of the home and enters a more formal setting – the outside world and the school.

In our view, Early Childhood Education (ECE) as a societal institution that mediates the cultural transmission of language is the locus to study both the acquisition and the learning aspects of language development, being where the acquisition component proceeds simultaneously with the learning component. It is 'the 'field' for investigating the robustness of theoretical formulations of both domain-specific properties as well as domain-general ones involved in the acquilearning of language. ECE is also the institution that can ease acquilearning, especially perhaps if the language being learnt is not the child's home language. Even though children do not necessarily imitate adult language, we propose that input in the early educational environment would benefit from an accessible understanding of the child's innate grammatical knowledge. Language games and activities rooted in acquilearning research can be built to address children's struggles, particularly with the learning component of acquilearning.

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